painting by William Hickey c. 1816, with the monumental Jain statue of Gomateshvara at Karkala in the background.

Having never encountered Jains, Mackenzie took little note of it, other than having a drawing made. But he had earlier received news of some unusual bas-reliefs unearthed further upriver by a minor ruler recently ousted by the EICo from his chiefdom who was building himself a new capital at a place called Amresvaram – now better known as Amaravati. They reached Amresvaram to find the raja supervising the extraction of bricks from an enormous mound which had originally been encircled with large stone slabs decorated with intricately carved bas-reliefs. ‘If the whole of the circle were faced with these slabs,’ conjectured Mackenzie, ‘it is to be regretted that this treasure of antiquity did not fall into better hands.’

Mackenzie had no idea what this ‘treasure of antiquity’ represented, although it was suggested to him that it was the remains of a Jain temple. As luck would have it, his official duties prevented him from returning to Amaravati until almost twenty years had passed, by which time most of the carved marble slabs that had at one time decorated what Mackenzie now knew to be a vast Buddhist stupa had vanished, along with most of the hemispherical mound that they had adorned – broken up and burned for lime or recycled as building material. Fearing for the survival of what remained, Mackenzie set his draughtsmen to make as many drawings as they could, while arranging for a number of slabs to be moved to the port of Masulipatnam, for onward transportation to Calcutta. However, the local Collector in Masulipatnam had other ideas and incorporated the slabs into a monument in the market-place that he named after himself ‘Robertson’s Mound’. These were subsequently rescued in the 1850s, some going to the Madras Museum and some going to London, where they